force on the island; a general air strike accompanied by a naval blockade of the island; and, finally, diplomacy. Robert Kennedy immediately reminded his brother of a fifth option—the invasion of Cuba. Now there were five options altogether, and only one of them was diplomatic.

John Kennedy clearly did not think much of diplomacy. In the past, Richard Nixon had suggested that Kennedy was incapable of standing up to Khrushchev. After the Vienna summit, Kennedy assumed that Khrushchev himself was of the same opinion, considering him "stupid" and having "no guts." "If he thinks I'm inexperienced and have no guts, until we remove those ideas we won't get anywhere with him," Kennedy told a sympathetic reporter after the summit. The news about the Soviet MRBMs on Cuba suggested that Kennedy had to do something drastic about the perception that he was a weak president.[13]

Kennedy assumed that appealing to Khrushchev might prompt the Soviets to speed up preparations for a nuclear strike. NATO allies would be of little help but might raise objections against a US attack on Soviet missile installations in Cuba: the Europeans had lived under the threat of Soviet missiles for years and would probably think of such an attack as making them vulnerable to Soviet retaliation. "I expect they'll just object," Kennedy told the gathering about the British. "Just have to decide to do it. Probably ought to tell them, though, the night before."[14]

Closer to the end of the meeting, Kennedy summarized all available options once again, but his own list had been reduced to two—a surgical strike against the missiles and a general strike. "I don't think we've got much time on these missiles," Kennedy told his advisers. "We can't wait two weeks while we're getting ready to roll." That was the time required to prepare an all-out invasion of the island. Kennedy's preferred solution was a surgical strike. "Maybe we just have to take them out and continue our other preparations if we decide to do that," suggested the president. He later added, with more conviction: "We're certainly going to [do] number one." He had in mind a surgical strike. It was up to him to show resolve and respond to Khrushchev before the information was leaked to Congress. He certainly did not want Kenneth Keating to become the next president of the United States.[15]